CHAPTER TWELVE

Jewish Anti-Zionism: From Critique to Delegitimization

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When Theodor Herzl first published his *Judenstaat* in Vienna in 1896, he was subjected to mocking sarcasm, above all by his Jewish contemporaries. Karl Kraus, Vienna's foremost satirst, in his notorious anti-Zionist pamphlet *Eine Kröne für Zion* (1898) mercilessly ridiculed the new would-be "King of the Jews" as a *grand poseur*, a perfumed Ringstrasse dandy, the perfect caricature of a Jewish messianic leader. Zionism, in his jaundiced view, offered the unpleasant spectacle of clumsy hands scratching at the 2000-year-old grave of an extinct people.[1]

The iconoclastic young journalist considered Herzl's Zionism to be the mirror image of the Christian-Social antisemitism that had come to power in Vienna only a year earlier. Kraus's insistence on the symmetry between Zionism and antisemitism remains an argument still potent in Jewish anti-Zionist rhetoric today. Indeed, for the past century this highly dubious claim has been paraded—whether by ultra-Orthodox rabbis or Reform Jews, by liberal assimilationists, Bundist socialists, Communist Jews, or contemporary New Leftists of various stripes.

Already a century ago, while seriously downplaying antisemitism as a significant threat to Jewish existence, anti-Zionists held Jews themselves to be responsible for its growing influence. Thus, Karl Kraus blamed *fin-de-siècle* French antisemitism on a so-called conspiracy by Jewish financial circles in France and their liberal allies, to mobilize public opinion behind the cause of the "traitor" Alfred Dreyfus. Similarly, the editor of Vienna's leading Social Democratic newspaper, the *Arbeiterzeitung*, Friedrich Austerlitz (a Czech-born Jew, who like Kraus, had secretly converted to Catholicism) considered Viennese antisemitism the direct result of the machinations of the "Jewish" liberal press. According to Austerlitz, the Jews "pursued every word that anyone dared to utter against them with the jealous hatred of their god Jehovah into the fourth generation."[2] Austerlitz (like most of the Jewish-born Marxists who led the Austrian labour movement) was a

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